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Trade Shifting from Efficiency to Resiliency: A Win for Shipping and Investors

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Last week, we had the opportunity to attend Marine Money Week, a three-day shipping industry conference held each year in New York. The tone at this year's conference was solidly optimistic, especially as it relates to the interplay between deglobalization and heightened geopolitical risk and the possibility of increased tonne-mile demand for vessels across various segments and classes. This note serves as a recap of major themes and takeaways from the conference and presents our thesis that maritime shipping equity assets are an interesting opportunity for investors to hedge against greater geopolitical risk and uncertainty.

The conference reinforced our view that maritime shipping is increasingly being shaped less by classical supply/demand and more by a structural overlay of geopolitics, trade fragmentation, infrastructure bottlenecks, and concerns around energy and supply-chain security. Across the dry bulk, tanker, LPG carrier, and LNG carrier segments, the clearest common thread is that global trade is becoming less efficient as globalization turns towards deglobalization, regionalization, confederation, and self-sufficiency. While these trends may not be great for global peace and stability, they are generally supportive of tonne-mile demand, utilization, and shipping rates.

Our core takeaway is that the shipping industry will continue to benefit from deglobalization trends, including strategic stockpiling of key commodities, the build-out of additional storage infrastructure, and increased regional security concerns around supply chains and energy security. In that vein, we believe that high-quality shipping companies with modern, more fuel-efficient fleets, relatively low reinvestment risk, balance sheet flexibility, and operational spot exposure will benefit in this environment. We continue to have Buy ratings on International Seaways (**INSW**) and Scorpio Tankers (**STNG**) in the tanker segment, Buy ratings on Genco (**GNK**) and Star Bulk Carriers (**SBLK**) in the dry bulk segment, and a Buy rating on Navigator Gas (**NVGS**) in the LPG carrier Segment. Beyond the "shipping-as-transport names, we also like the geopolitical backdrop for companies such as Excelerate Energy (**EE**) and Golar LNG (**GLNG**) in the marine-based LNG value chain, and Venture Global (**VG**) in the land-based LNG liquefaction segment.

Geopolitics is no longer a background variable – it drives trade patterns

Several panel discussions came back to the same point: the shipping market is being reshaped by a world that is becoming less integrated and more security-focused, especially after the latest closure in the Strait of Hormuz and conflicts in the Middle East. Owners and operators expect global trade to evolve towards



more regionalization, self-sufficiency, confederation, and/or balkanization. While globalization of trade has been a major driver of cargo volumes, a deglobalization trend may not necessarily imply less trade, but rather longer voyage distances, lower logistical efficiencies, more strategic storage requirements, and higher redundancies in supply chains. This combination should be fundamentally supportive for shipping tonne-mile demand and rates. When voyages are longer, loading/discharge is slower and less efficient, and vessels reroute or avoid unsafe or dangerous regions, the result is the same: less effective available supply.

As it relates to the Strait of Hormuz, tanker owners are looking for the following conditions to be met before returning to the region: 1) a full cessation of hostilities in the region and several weeks or months of no hostile attacks on ships or other marine infrastructure; 2) safe and unrestricted travel conditions that are not hampered by various state or military actors; 3) normalization of insurance prices and availability, and; 4) stabilization in the broader region. One panel participant noted that these conditions have not been met at the current time even if headline diplomacy has improved. Ship owners remain cautious around risks to their crews and to their assets. Owners believe that the current conflict will encourage additional investment in storage infrastructure in various countries and regions as a way to further bolster strategic oil reserves. The peace agreement is still relatively fragile, especially as it relates to big questions around whether hostilities between Israel and Lebanon will persist.

Notably, tanker owners were quite positive around the prospect for sanctions relief on Iranian oil and what this could mean for demand for compliant, mainstream tonnage. The Iranian dark fleet primarily consists of older, less maintained vessels. These vessels were popular among smaller, Chinese refiners when Iranian oil was trading at a significant discount, and these ships were the only options. Should sanctions on Iranian oil be lifted, then demand for newer, better maintained and compliant ships should increase. A real-world example of this dynamic can be seen in Venezuela today where previously sanctioned crude volumes are now being lifted using mainstream, compliant vessels, displacing dark-fleet activity.

China - Remains a key driver of commodity import demand

A notable conference panelist said that he continues to be surprised when his Western colleagues visit China for the first time and they are surprised by the current living and economic standards, economic resilience, and technological advancement. These direct observations challenge previous notions or biases and matters for shipping into two important ways: 1) Even if China is not re-accelerating in the classic property-led model, it remains the marginal buyer of many bulk and energy commodities, and; 2) China's policy orientation is increasing strategic, focusing on greater integration of its global supply chain via the Belt and Road initiative which includes sourcing, transporting, storing and stockpiling, and use of various strategic commodities. Given trade frictions between China and the US and between China and Australia in recent years, we believe that China will continue towards more self-sufficiency and supply-chain diversification.

LNG and related marine-based energy infrastructure remain a theme

The conference reinforced that LNG-related infrastructure and other marine-based energy infrastructure remains a durable theme. A growing number of market participants are evaluating opportunities through the lens of: 1)



geopolitical risk diversification; 2) energy security; 3) price index diversification, and; 4) infrastructure optionality and flexibility. There was also increasing recognition that adjacent gas derivatives, including ethane, could become more relevant in smaller market. We believe this theme will be beneficial for Golar (GLNG), Excelebrate (EE), and Navigator Gas (NVGS).

[Dry bulk fundamentals remain supported by tonne-mile growth and slow speeds](#)

Turning to the dry bulk segment, commentary was constructive around rising commodity flows from West Africa and South America into China, including iron ore, bauxite, and grains. Slow steaming speeds and higher fuel prices have also helped reduce effective supply in the current market. These trends continue to support tonne-mile demand and rates going forward.

Bauxite exports from Guinea have doubled since 2020 and have been a meaningful driver of tonne-mile demand. That said, Guinea has proposed an export cap of ~150 Mt in 2026, roughly 15% below 2025 levels. This could be an important swing factor.

It was noted by one speaker that iron ore imports into China have been decreasing in quality in recent quarters. This has positive implications for iron ore trade volumes as it takes more iron ore of lower quality to produce the same amount of steel compared with higher-quality ore. This might be an underappreciated support factor for dry bulk demand.

China has resumed purchases of US grains, along with stockpiling corn from Argentina. This points to a strategy of agricultural stockpiling as a security hedge.

[Tanker demand fundamentals look positive, but monitoring growth in orderbook](#)

The conference tone on tankers remained positive, with a strong emphasis on three key themes: 1) geopolitical factors will continue to drive trade inefficiency; 2) tinkering ordering has increased but should be balanced by the current, aging fleet, and; 3) current secondhand asset values are great for sellers of older tonnage.

There was broad agreement by several panelists that it is a good seller's market for owners looking to divest older, less fuel efficient ships. In turn, this cash can be returned to shareholders or held back as cash on the balance sheet as treated like an "option" to engage in purchase and acquisitions in the future when the market eventually turns. This is especially attractive for companies with relatively modern fleet, like Scorpio (STNG), because they can monetize older, non-core assets, while not running into a complete wall due to lack of operating assets.

A major discussion point was that 10-15% of the current tanker fleet is currently tied to sanctioned or dark-fleet vessels. If Iranian sanctions are eased or lifted, the immediate effect may be more mainstream and compliant ships displacing dark fleet or non-compliant ships. This would be a net positive for mainstream tanker demand and rates. It was noted that smaller Chinese refineries were benefiting from the use of Iranian-linked dark fleet vessels largely because of discounted Iranian crude prices. If sanctions are lifted, then there will be less of an incentive to use sub-standard ships.

While the crude tanker orderbook has moved up in recent months, the overall message was not overly-bearish as: 1) deliveries are spread out over many years, with most of the orders delivering in 2028 or beyond; 2) the existing fleet is fairly



old and will continue to age between now and then, and 3) current order levels remain below historical peaks. This suggests that while supply pressure is building, it is not necessarily at a critical breaking point, especially in the next 12 to 24 months.

Supply, orderbooks, and asset prices

One of the more concerning trends was around the increase in newbuilding orders in the crude tanker and product tanker segments, with crude tanker newbuilding orders accelerating in recent months. That said, newbuilding prices remain elevated and this is discouraging a rush of speculative orders and helping preserve some supply disciplines. Many owners remain reluctant to place speculative orders but may order some newbuilding assets as a means of normal-course fleet renewal. Secondhand asset prices remain robust and many owners are taking advantage of the current market to divest older, less efficient assets.

Conference commentary suggested that while newbuilding prices may ease in the coming years, the current delivery schedule now puts new assets squarely in 2029 or even in 2030. Ship yards remain full in the near term and a higher structural floor may have been established. If true, this means that: 1) fleet replacement becomes more expensive or cost prohibitive; 2) NAV support for public shipping equities could improve; 3) modern tonnage should command a larger premium compared to older, less fuel efficient assets.

Regulations and technology – part of everyday operations, but less of a focus

Compared with previous years, there were far fewer discussions on decarbonization and green technology. This does not mean that regulation has gone away, but it appears to have been largely displaced by more urgent discussions around trade dislocations and geopolitical disruptions. The regulatory discussion appears to be shifting towards more regional implementation, including at the Port of Singapore. We view the possibility of more regional regulatory templates moving faster than global frameworks.

Unlike some of the more speculative AI narratives in other sectors, the maritime use case presented at the conference felt much more concrete and applicable to real-world, analog applications. The focus was on the use of AI for 1) predictive maintenance and downtime forecasting and management; 2) route optimization, and; 3) digitization and analysis of largely hand-written reports and materials within the sector. The implications are better uptimes on assets, lower maintenance costs (all else equal), improved voyage planning, and better asset utilization. For asset-heavy sectors like shipping, modest improvements in operations can have meaningful economic value to things like operating availability and reduced opex.

Deglobalization, geopolitical risk, and trade

While globalization and internationalization of trade has been a key factor for growth in trade volumes, the key analytical mistake of looking at trends in deglobalization would be to assume that fragmentation will necessarily hurt tonne-mile demand. A fragmented and increasingly complex global supply chain and geopolitical environment can be supportive for shipping if shifting trade patterns result in: 1) longer voyage distances; 2) more rerouting occurs; 3) more stockpiling and inventory building occurs; 4) there is less efficient loading/discharge activities at smaller, less-sophisticated terminal and ports, and; 5) regionalization of regulations creates even more complexity.



Summary and Final Thoughts

The bottom line is that the shipping market is becoming increasingly complex and that shipping is a hedge against geopolitical risk and uncertainty. This is uncomfortable from a geopolitical perspective, but constructive in terms of potential earnings power. From an equity standpoint, the winners should be those companies that can translate this new operating backdrop into shareholder value through capital discipline, balance sheet flexibility, and robust shareholder returns. Ship owners should benefit from the move from maximizing trade efficiency to optimizing around trade and supply chain resiliency.

We leave you with a sobering quote from French economist, Frederic Bastiat, who said that *"...what would be the use of large standing armies and powerful navies if trade were free..."*

Companies that will benefit from deglobalization, trade inefficiency, and greater global focus on energy security and supply-chain diversification:

- Star Bulk Carriers (**SBLK**) and Genco Shipping (**GNK**), dry bulk segment
 - Increased tonne-mile demand due to greater voyage distances and supply diversification in iron ore, bauxite, and grains.
 - Greater inefficiencies in loading dry bulk commodities in West Africa compared to other regions.
 - Higher fuel prices will encourage ongoing slow-steaming of the fleet, limiting some effective supply.
- International Seaways (**INSW**) and Scorpio Tankers (**STNG**), tanker segment
 - Lasting energy security concerns, supply-chain diversification, and stockpiling should drive demand for crude oil and refined products, resulting in greater demand for tankers.
 - Sanctions relief on Iranian oil may incentivize demand for mainstream (not dark fleet) tankers, much like in Venezuela.
- Navigator Holdings (**NVGS**), LPG carrier and petchem export infrastructure segment
 - Similar to crude, refined oil products and LNG, the current conflict in the Middle East has disrupted global petchem supply chains and security of supply. As such, we believe that the abundance of cost-advantaged US gas-derived products such as ethylene, ethane, etc., will remain a cost-advantage source of supply.
 - Opportunities for additional smaller-scale infrastructure projects along the non-Methane gas value chain.
- Excelerate Energy (**EE**), FSRU segment
 - Greater need for flexibility in the LNG import market and additional need for stockpiling and storing LNG. Should help



drive underlying demand for FSRUs and other regasification infrastructure.

- Golar LNG (**GLNG**), marine-based FLNG segment
 - Greater focus on energy security and supply-chain diversification by buyers of LNG in Europe and in Asia should drive demand for non-US Gulf and non-Qatari LNG liquefaction infrastructure, resulting in additional contract opportunities.
- Venture Global (**VG**), US land-based LNG liquefaction segment
 - In line with the increased global focus on energy security and supply-chain resiliency, we believe LNG from the US Gulf Coast will continue to be a vitally important part of the global energy mix, resulting in more opportunities for Venture Global to lock in longer-duration sales agreements with European and Asian buyers of LNG.



Appendix 1

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